our promised levels of commitment and performance. This, remember, was at a time when analytics in cricket was in relative infancy. By the time of the 2017 Ashes, ‘Numbers’ was breaking down the pitch into twenty blocks, each 100×15 cm, to illustrate the optimal block for each bowler to target against individual batsmen.

Modern players devour the video footage sent to their online Dropboxes. Coaching staff utilize a match-specific dossier, combining video and statistical analysis. Computer simulations factor in weather forecasts and analysis of the pitch surface. Though our game still lags behind Major League Baseball in this area, since MLB’s 162-game regular season is a more comprehensive sample size and their sport has fewer variables, it is catching up fast.

A mathematical equation still can’t be framed to include the influence of mutual trust and respect. Human factors require greater sensitivity, more subtle consideration. The Ashes series in 2009 was the first time I had been in an England team with a truly common purpose. We needed only to look around the room to realize our aspirations were realistic.

Most of the group had been through the initial cycle of international cricket, which features success, failure, survival and revival. That process is vital, because anyone who emerges with his game intact and his mind fresh has a good chance of longevity and substantial success. The principle applies across sport; England rugby union coach Eddie Jones points out that the profile of a World Cup-winning team features players who have won a total of between 750 and 800 caps.

In my first Test, against India in 2006, Michael Vaughan had made fifteen Test hundreds, and Andrew Strauss seven. Ian Bell and KP had two apiece. Paul Collingwood, like myself, made his maiden hundred in Nagpur. The core of the Indian team had scored between ten and thirty centuries each. Not quite men against boys, but maturity offers an obvious advantage.

It took less than half an hour to appreciate the logic of the next phase of team development, focusing on the notion of our so-called super-strengths. This had its greatest impact once we had reclaimed the Ashes, following a warm-up series at home against the West Indies, where I played myself into a modicum of form by scoring 160 in the second Test at Chester-le-Street.

I was nowhere near my peak and failed to make another century that summer (the next would come on Boxing Day, in Durban). However, without making any assumptions of selection, I felt secure within the group.